

“...THE SCANDAL OF CHRISTENDOM AND A DISGRACE TO YOU.”

Catherine of Aragon to Henry VIII about Anne Boleyn, 1533

HENRY VIII OF ENGLAND had been awarded the title *Fidei Defensor*—Defender of the Faith—by Pope Leo X in 1521 in recognition of his vehement defense of the Catholic Church against Protestant attacks. Henry would remain a devout Catholic to the end of his life, opposed to all attempts to reform Catholic practice. And yet by 1533 he had been excommunicated from the Roman Church. The following year, he completed the rupture, establishing a national church, totally independent from Rome, with himself as its “supreme head.” The reasons for this improbable split were simple. Initially, Henry wanted a **divorce** from his aging Spanish wife, **Catherine of Aragon**, who after 24 years of marriage had yet to give birth to a son. Henry had



Anne Boleyn
Henry VIII married Anne Boleyn in secret in January 1533, four months before he divorced Catherine of Aragon. She was crowned in June.

THE JESUIT ORDER

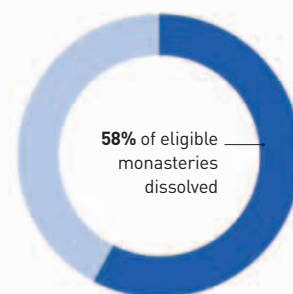
The initial Catholic response to the Reformation was hesitant and uncoordinated, and was led by a series of individuals rather than the Church itself. The Jesuits, the Society of Jesus, were established in 1534 by a Basque nobleman, Ignatius of Loyola. Loyola's goal was to produce a new generation of highly educated priests to spread a new militantly Catholic faith. Given papal sanction in 1540, the Jesuits spearheaded the Catholic revival.

convinced himself this was divine punishment for marrying his brother's widow—in 1501, Catherine had married Henry's elder brother Arthur, who died the following year; Henry and Catherine married in 1509. The pope, under pressure from Catherine's nephew, Charles V, refused to grant a divorce. Henry's response, formulated over several years, was in effect to become his own pope, able to authorize his own divorce. Prompted in addition by the knowledge that, as elsewhere in Europe, any ruler asserting control of the Church in his own country would necessarily increase his own authority, in 1534 the **Church of England** was brought into being under the Act of Supremacy. In pursuit of Henry's personal interests, **Roman Catholicism was abolished.**

HAVING BROKEN WITH ROME, it followed that all the structures of the Catholic Church in England should be taken over by the state. This was not just a question of wanting to eradicate papal authority in England. The Catholic Church in England was immensely wealthy, and this was money that Henry VIII, permanently strapped for cash, was determined to have. In 1535, the king's secretary, **Thomas Cromwell** (c. 1485–1540), took charge of the two-part **dissolution of the country's monasteries**. Starting in 1536 and culminating with all the great monasteries in 1539, the dissolution involved systematic vandalism and saw the greatest transfer of land ownership in England since the Norman Conquest in 1066. Every one of the 560 monasteries in England was

suppressed, yielding the crown an additional income of around £200,000 *per annum*. However, within years the money was gone, squandered by the king.

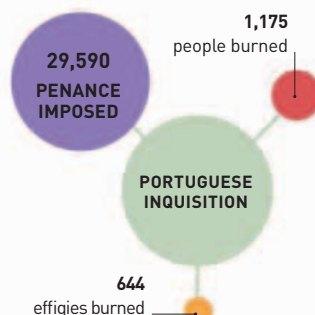
Henry VIII's divorce from Catherine of Aragon in 1533 had been necessary to allow him to marry **Anne Boleyn**. When she, too, failed to produce a son, Henry had her executed on **charges of adultery** in 1536. In the same year, tensions at the pace and extent of religious change, and the sincere concerns of many that the break with Rome signaled larger changes in the fabric of the traditional Church, had reached the boiling point in the North of England. The **Pilgrimage of Grace** saw the largest uprisings in England since the Peasants Revolt in 1381. Those involved had shown little or no dissatisfaction with the Catholic church and were unprepared to see centuries of settled faith discarded. Faced with protest on this scale, the king



Dissolution of monasteries
Under the Dissolution of Lesser Monasteries Act of 1536, 243 of the 419 eligible monasteries were suppressed or dissolved.



Charles V's seizure of Tunis in June 1535 was almost the only unequivocal success of his reign. Briefly, the prospect of a resurgent Christendom loomed.



Portuguese Inquisition
Between 1540 and 1794, tribunals held in Lisbon, Porto, Coimbra, and Evora led to the death by burning of 1,175 people, most of them Jews.

conceded to the movement's demands. But when the crisis was over, he had the rebellion's leaders executed.

Distracted by events in Europe, Charles V was rarely able to pursue his goal of driving the Ottomans back to their Turkish heartlands. In 1535, however, he achieved a rare success with the **conquest of Tunis** in North Africa. It proved to be a costly victory, provoking an Ottoman raid on Majorca that captured 6,000 Christians and encouraged the French monarch to cooperate more closely with the Ottomans.

While it never achieved the notoriety of its Spanish equivalent (see 1480), the **Portuguese Inquisition**, founded in 1536, was nonetheless vigorous in rooting out heresy in Portugal and, from 1560, in its colonies, such as Goa. Its chief target was Jews, many originally Spanish, who were forcibly converted to Catholicism.

